



Hakhel - The power of community connection and inclusion

"At the end of every seven years... When all Israel comes to appear before the Lord, your G-d, in the place He will choose, you shall read this Torah before all Israel, in their ears. Assemble the people: the men, the women, the children..."
Deuteronomy 31:10-12.

There is a story told of two great Chassidic mystics, The Ropschitzer Rebbe and the Rimonovert Rebbe, who were best friends. Even though they lived close by, their respective jobs kept them too busy to see each other often. However, rather than let their friendship fall by the wayside, they would send each other handwritten letters every week, which a secretary delivered. For years, this secretary walked the letters back and forth across the forest every week. One day, curiosity got the best of him, and he opened the letter. What could these friends possibly be sharing with each other? Inside the letter read as follows:

'To my dear friend, the holy Rimonovert Rebbe,' followed by a full sheet of blank paper, signed 'Your dear friend, the Ropschitzer Rebbe.'

The secretary couldn't believe it! Surely, he thought, the letter from the Rimonovert Rebbe would contain much more details. To his surprise, the second letter was identical to the first!

The secretary was fuming. When he returns to the Ropschitzer Rebbe, he laid out his frustrations. How could he be sending him on a mission to deliver an empty letter every week for years?!

To this, the Rebbe responded: "The letters you have been carrying all these years were indeed letters which contained profound messages. You see, when two people have a friendship as deep and as close as the Rimonoverts and me, you don't need to write out the words. We understand each other so perfectly well that all we need to do is read between the lines!"

Their friendship, regardless of distance, was a necessary and important part of their lives. So too, with our friendships.

The world has seen an uptick in mental health challenges in the last ten years. Rates of depression, anxiety, and suicide deaths are on the rise in teens and adults alike. A major contributor to mental health struggles is increased loneliness and isolation. On the one hand, we're the most connected generation to ever grace this planet. With social media, video calls, and instant communication, it feels like we are only a ping away from connecting with those we love. And yet, society shows us a different story.

While loneliness itself is not a mental health problem, there are links between the two. Studies show that increased isolation and loneliness can exacerbate an individual's mental health struggles. In fact, loneliness and social isolation are twice as harmful to physical and mental health as obesity.

A balm to cure the ache caused by loneliness is social connection. As humans, we are not meant to do things alone. That's not how Hashem created us. We need our "partners" in this life too: Friends, community, Rabbis, leaders, and people we can turn to in good times and bad.

The "theme" of this year is Hakhel or gathering. In Temple times, the Jewish nation would gather every seven years, to learn Torah together and gain strength from each other. Hakhel is the epitome of connection. Hakhel focuses on the power in numbers, but it goes beyond that. There is a power that can occur only when each and every individual is counted.

In a letter written in 1966, The Lubavitcher Rebbe discussed the importance of Hakhel, saying: "The Mitzvah of Hakhel reminds us that wherever Jews are and however dispersed they may be, each one remains an integral part of the Hakhel-people, the one people, through embodying in himself and in his daily life the one Torah..."

The message of Hakhel is that each of us matters, and that we are significant in our own unique ways. Each of us has something special to contribute, and without YOU, we're not complete. In this world where isolation reigns supreme, let's do our part to change that but turning to each other, offering love, support, and friendship, to ease the pain of the challenges we face.